



New Resident Quick Start

Your first week in Boulder Creek, in order. Boulder Creek is unincorporated Santa Cruz County, so there's no city hall handling any of this; services come from a patchwork of county departments and special districts. This sheet walks you through each one.

1 Sign up for emergency alerts before you unpack

This is mountain country, and fire season, winter storms, and power outages are part of the deal. Register for CruzAware, the official Santa Cruz County alert system, at cruzaware.org. It takes a few minutes online and should be the first account you create at your new address.

While you're at it, set up PG&E outage alerts. Account holders get notifications for their service address automatically once contact info is current, and you can also follow any address on the outage map without an account.

Two more numbers for your phone: the county's 24-hour road dispatch line, (831) 477-3999, for a tree or slide blocking a county road, and PG&E's 24-hour outage line, 1-800-743-5002. If a line is down or anyone's in danger, it's 911 first, always.

2 Put the utilities in your name

Electricity and gas come from PG&E; customer service is 1-877-660-6789, around the clock. Start there if the previous owner or tenant hasn't already closed the account. Don't assume gas: some addresses have PG&E natural gas and many mountain properties rely on delivered propane instead, so check what's actually connected before buying appliances.

Water for most homes comes from the San Lorenzo Valley Water District, whose office sits right on the main drag at 13060 Highway 9; call (831) 338-2153, office open weekdays 8:30 to noon and 1 to 5. To start service, fill out the district's Start/Stop Service form at least 24 business hours before you need water in your name, and expect a \$20 establishment fee on your first monthly bill. One quirk renters should know: the district keeps accounts in the property owner's name, so if you're leasing, your landlord handles the water account. Not every property is on district water; plenty are on private wells or small shared systems, so if you're buying, get the water and septic answers in writing before escrow closes.

Septic or sewer: most homes here treat wastewater on-site with a septic system, overseen by Santa Cruz County Environmental Health, (831) 454-2022. A portion of town near the core is on the county-run CSA 7 sewer instead; a sewer charge on the property tax bill is the tell.

Propane is a private, competitive market rather than an assigned utility, so shop: call two or three suppliers, ask neighbors who they use, and get current pricing in writing. Learn to read the tank's percentage gauge and don't let it run low heading into a stretch of winter storms.

3 Set up trash service (it's required)

Garbage, recycling, and organics in unincorporated Santa Cruz County come from GreenWaste. Call (831) 426-2711 or email SantaCruzCS@GreenWaste.com to set up carts, confirm your collection day, and ask about backyard service if your driveway is the kind of driveway this town is famous for. Collection days vary street by street.

Service is now mandatory: under the county's universal service requirement, every developed property must subscribe with GreenWaste or register with the county as a self-hauler, with a compliance deadline of November 1, 2026 and fines that start at \$100. For big cleanouts, the county lists (831) 454-2430 for landfill and recycling questions, and the Ben Lomond Transfer Station at 9835 Newell Creek Road takes household hazardous waste (paint, batteries, pesticides, motor oil) on Thursdays 7:30 am to 3:30 pm; bring proof of residency, questions to (831) 454-2606.

4 Enroll kids in school

Boulder Creek sits in the San Lorenzo Valley Unified School District, TK through 12th grade for the whole valley. Enrollment starts with a person, not a portal: contact your school's registrar first to set up pre-enrollment, then finish online registration within a

week. The in-town elementary campus is Boulder Creek Elementary at 400 Lomond Street; district Student Services is (831) 336-9678.

Have ready: proof of your child's age, immunization records, an oral health assessment for TK, kindergarten, and first grade, and proof of address (utility bill, lease, property tax receipt, or similar). For the 2026-27 year, kindergartners need to be five on or before September 1, and TK students need to turn four by that date.

5 Get a library card

The Boulder Creek branch of Santa Cruz Public Libraries, 13390 West Park Avenue, punches well above its weight after a full remodel: free WiFi, computers, kids' programs, and a local history collection. Hours: Monday through Thursday 10 am to 6 pm, Friday 11 am to 5 pm, Saturday 10 am to 5 pm, closed Sunday. One of the best rainy-day rooms in the valley.

6 Learn the bus before you need it

Santa Cruz METRO Route 35 (the Highway 9/Scotts Valley line) connects Boulder Creek to Felton, Scotts Valley, and downtown Santa Cruz, with in-town timepoints at Highway 9 and Middleton Avenue and stops out to the Country Club end of Big Basin Way. On weekdays, Route 35X, the Santa Cruz/Boulder Creek Express, skips part of the Scotts Valley routing during commute hours. Schedules shift with service changes, so check the live pages at scmetro.org before building a commute around them.

7 Know who to actually call

Fire protection is the Boulder Creek Fire Protection District, station at 13230 Central Avenue; the office line, (831) 338-7222, is for non-emergency business, weekdays 8 to 5. There's no Boulder Creek police department: law enforcement is the Santa Cruz County Sheriff's Office, which staffs a Boulder Creek Service Center at 13210 Central Avenue, (831) 454-7440, with a community deputy. For things that need a deputy but not lights and sirens, non-emergency dispatch is (831) 471-1121. Emergencies always go through 911.

8 Cover the everyday basics in town

You can handle most errands without leaving Boulder Creek. Johnnie's Super Market, 13225 Highway 9, has anchored town since 1938: full grocery, produce, meat, deli, and a serious wine and spirits section, open daily from 8 am. Wild Roots Market, 13159 Central Avenue, is the natural-foods counterpart, open daily 9 to 9 with a deli kitchen and local produce. Boulder Creek Pharmacy, 13081 Central Avenue, is an independent with free delivery throughout the San Lorenzo Valley, open weekdays 9 to 6 and Saturday 10 to 4. And for the endless small fixes an older mountain house demands, Scarborough Home & Garden, 13110 Highway 9, stocks Ace Hardware lines seven days a week.

9 Spend your first weekend like a local

Walk the town. The Boulder Creek Recreation and Park District runs Junction Park at Middleton and Railroad Avenues, with a small beach and river access a block from downtown, and Garrahan Park at 15555 Highway 9, with a walking track, soccer field, and play structures, open sunrise to sunset. Dogs are welcome on leash at both. The district's downtown office, (831) 338-4144, can fill you in on classes, camps, and community events, which are the fastest way to stop feeling new here.

ONE MORE THING: INTERNET

Availability genuinely varies street by street up here, so skip the provider lists. Put your exact address into the FCC National Broadband Map (broadbandmap.fcc.gov), confirm with each provider's own address checker, and ask the closest neighbors what they actually use and how it holds up in winter. And remember that home internet and cordless phones die with the power; if you work from home, think through your outage fallback.